Compare two pages – side by side, overlaid or with a curtain

Need to see whether two pages are identical – or exactly where they differ? In **compare mode**, OpenDocViewer (ODV) shows two pages side by side. You can then lay them on top of each other or drag a border between them, so that even small differences stand out. Everything you set lasts only until you load new documents. The documents in the archive are never changed.

This guide belongs with Getting started with OpenDocViewer. The pictures show a made-up test document in the Swedish interface; the button names in the text are the English ones. Download the guide as PDF.

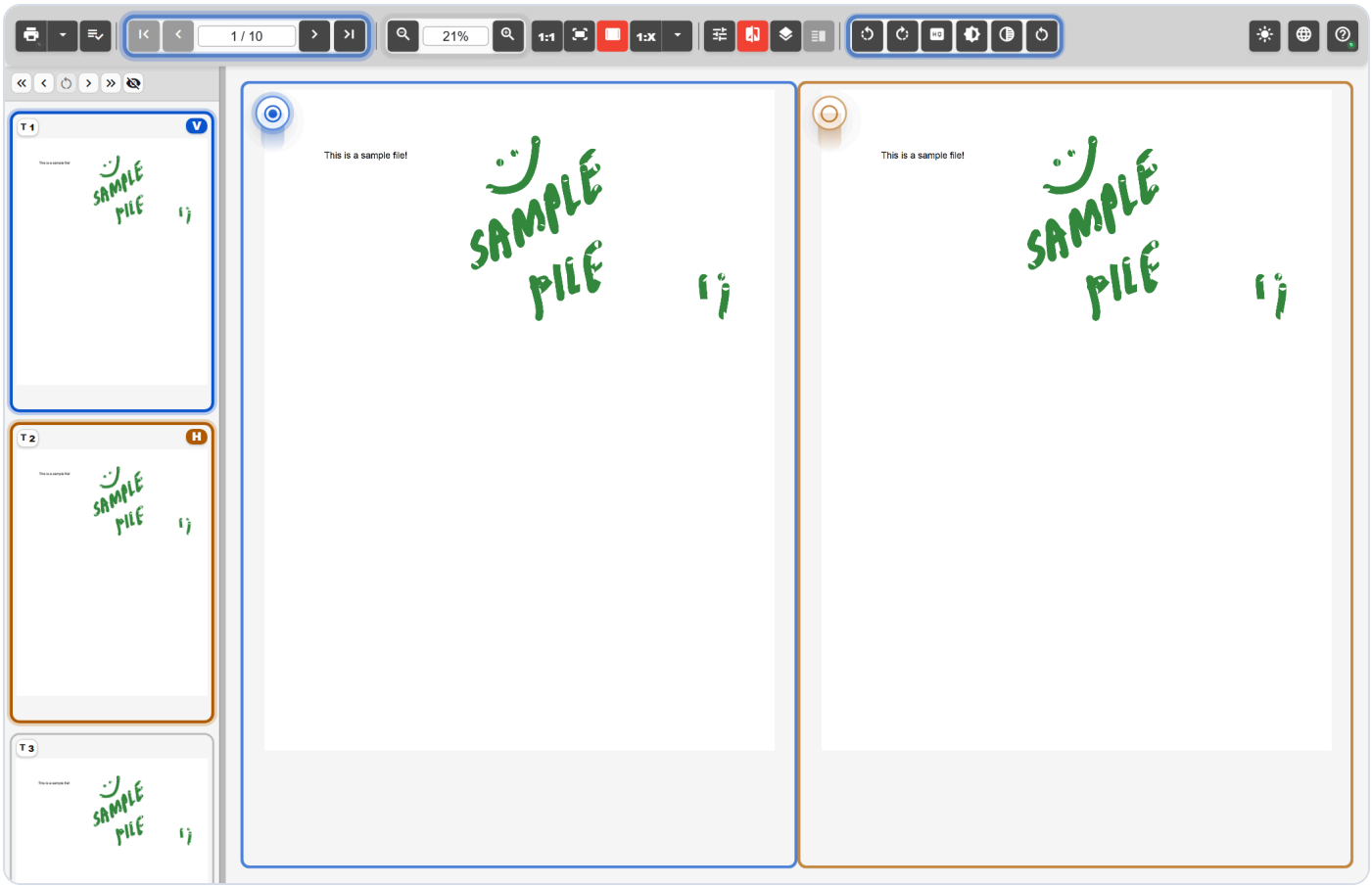
Tip: everything in this guide is included from the start, but your organization may have switched parts of it off – see What your organization may have switched off. If a button described here is missing, that is probably why.

1. Open the comparison and pick the pages
2. The adjustments follow the page (calibration)
3. Fine-tune each page
4. Lay the pages on top of each other (overlay)
5. Drag a border between the pages (curtain)
6. Print from the comparison
7. What your organization may have switched off
8. The keys in the comparison

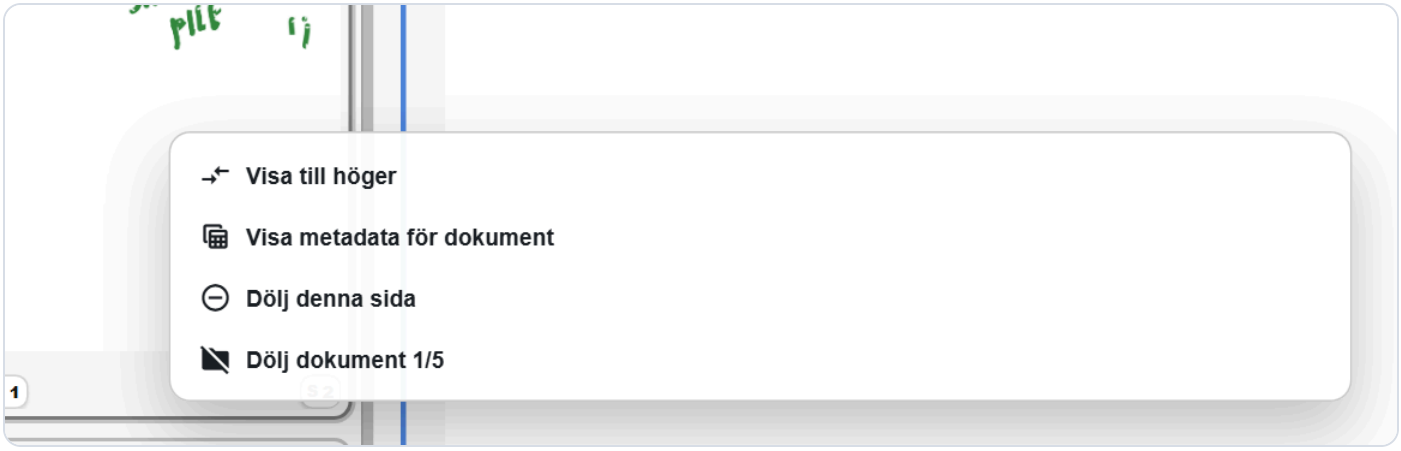
1. Open the comparison and pick the pages

1. Click the **compare button** in the toolbar (*Enable compare mode*), to the right of the 1:X and Fine tuning buttons. The page you are looking at is shown on the left with a **blue frame** and a second page on the right with an **orange frame** – the first time the same page, later the one you last compared with.

2 **Right-click a thumbnail** and choose *Show to right*. The page is shown on the right.



Compare mode. The left page has a blue frame, the right page an orange one. The ring at the top left of each page shows which one is active, and in the thumbnail pane the pages are marked **L** and **R** (**V** and **H** in the pictures, which show the Swedish interface).



Right-clicking a thumbnail. *Show to right* (*Visa till höger* in the picture) puts the page on the right in the comparison – even when compare mode is off; it is then switched on at the same time.

This is how the colors and letters fit together, in the guide and in ODV:

Left page	Right page
Blue frame. Marked **L** in the thumbnail pane (**V** in the pictures). Called **A** in the overlay view and the curtain view.	**Orange frame**. Marked **R** in the thumbnail pane (**H** in the pictures). Called **B** in the overlay view and the curtain view.

The view with the two pages side by side is called the **compare view**. One of the pages is always **active**: when you open the comparison with the compare button, `Arrow Right` or *Show to right*, it is the right page; after that, the one you last clicked in. The ring at the top left of the active page is filled, and you can click a ring to switch. The page box, the arrow buttons, the keyboard and the image adjustments apply to the active page. The frames around the toolbar buttons show which one: blue for left, orange for right.

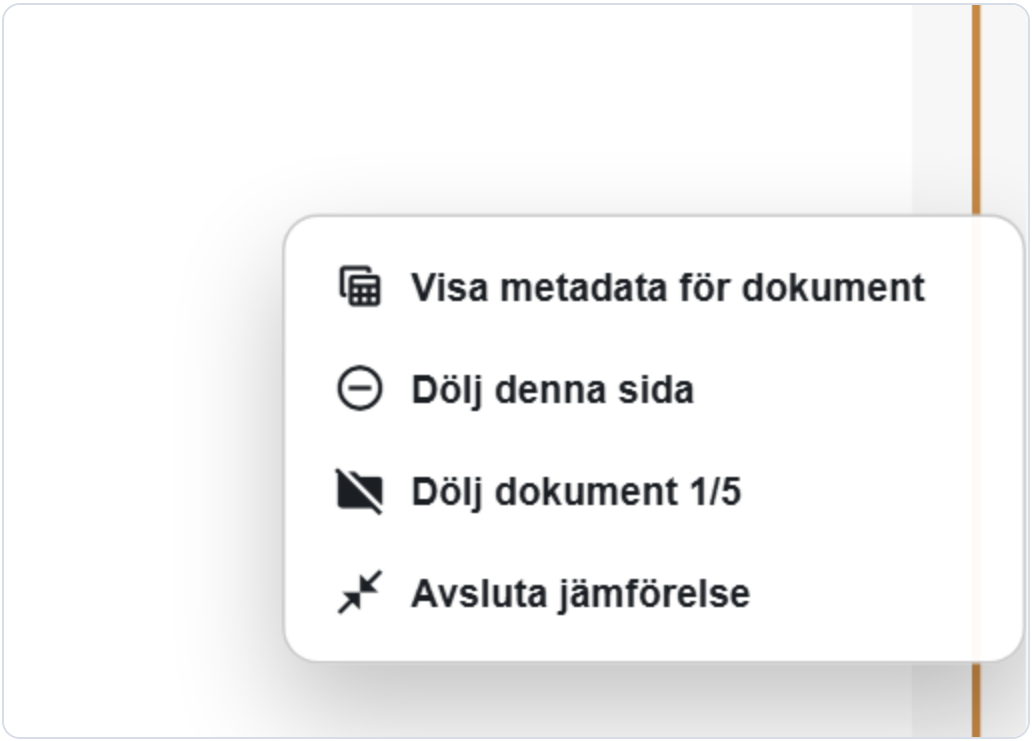
<details>
<summary>More ways to open the comparison and switch pages</summary>

- Click a thumbnail to replace the active page. `Shift`+click replaces the other page. If compare mode is off, it is switched on.
- `Arrow Right` does the same as the compare button. If the comparison is already running, the key instead makes the right page active, and `Arrow Left` makes the left page active.
- Hold `Shift` while you click a button or press a key, and the command applies to the page that is *not* active – one click or key press at a time. The frames change color while you hold Shift.



Shift held down. Orange frames = the buttons control the right page right now.
</details>

End the comparison with the compare button (*Disable compare mode*), with `Arrow Left` when the left page is already active, or with *Close comparison* in the right-click menu on the right page. Your adjustments are still there if you switch compare mode on again.



Right-clicking the right page. The usual options, plus *Close comparison* (*Avsluta jämförelse* in the picture) last in the menu.

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2. The adjustments follow the page (calibration)

Two pages rarely line up exactly. One of them may be slightly shifted, slightly tilted or scanned at a different scale. So you adjust each page on its own – zoom, position, rotation and image – until they match. ODV calls this **calibration**.

- The adjustments **belong to the page**. If you switch to another page and then back, they are still there. A page you have not touched is unadjusted.
- They **follow the page** between the three views: the compare view (side by side), the overlay view and the curtain view.
- They **disappear** when you load new documents. Nothing is saved in the archive or on the server.

The curtain button in the toolbar is gray until you have opened the overlay view once – only then does ODV count the pages as calibrated. Its tooltip says *Curtain: open the overlay view first – it calibrates the two pages*. If you end the comparison, you need to open the overlay view again before the curtain can be opened. See Lay the pages on top of each other and Drag a border between the pages.



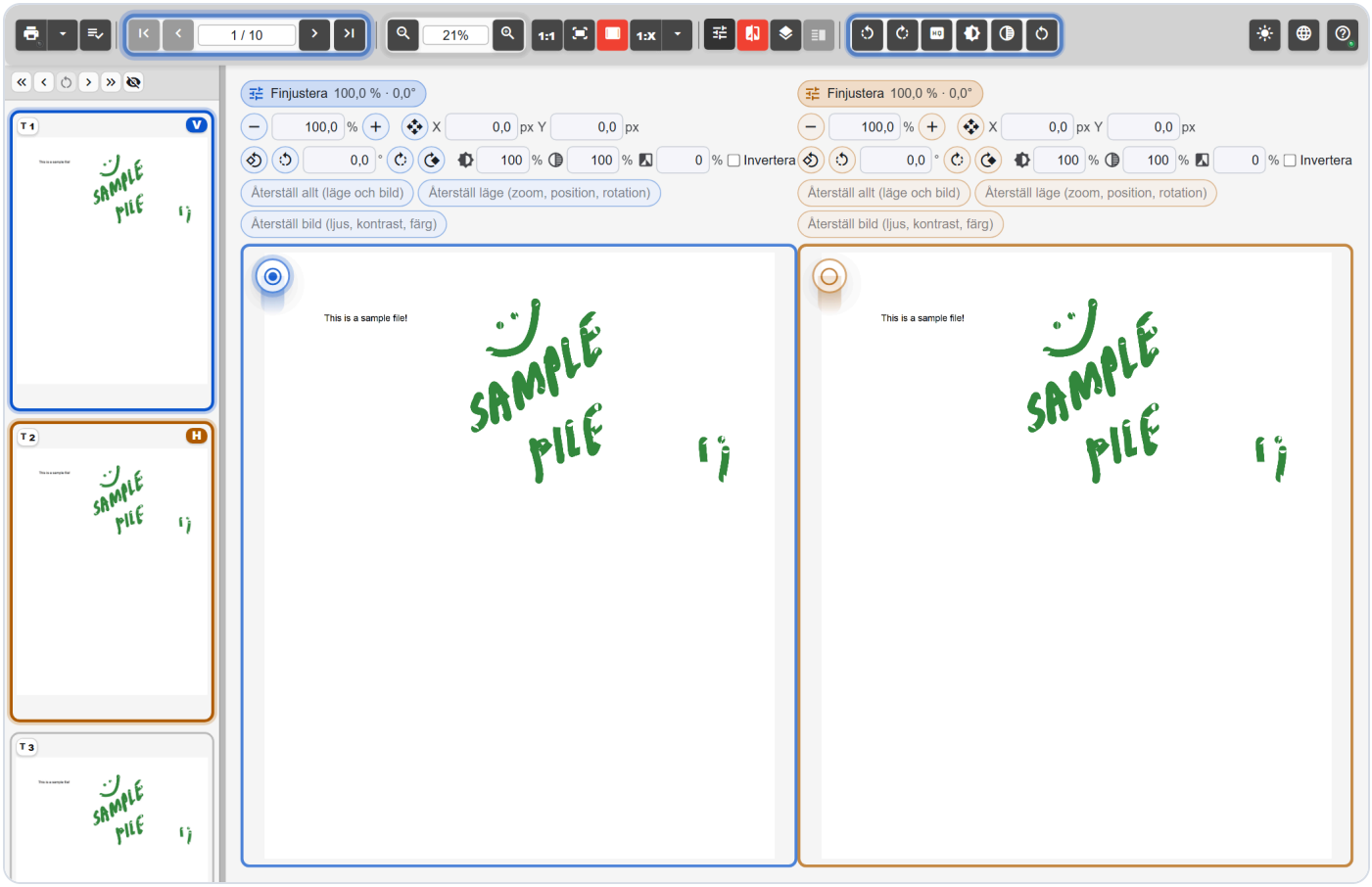
The toolbar in compare mode. From the left: Fine tuning, compare (on), overlay and curtain. The curtain button is gray until the pages are calibrated.

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3. Fine-tune each page

The **Fine-tune** panel is the tool for calibration. It sits above each page – both pages in compare mode, or the single page when you are not comparing.

1. Click **Fine tuning** in the toolbar (the button with the sliders, next to the compare button). The **Fine-tune** panel is shown expanded above each page.
2. Change zoom, position, rotation or image in the panel until the page sits the way you want it. You can also drag the page to move it.
3. Click **Fine tuning** again when you are done. The panels are hidden, but the adjustments are kept.



The Fine-tune panel. Zoom, position, rotation and image for one page, and at the bottom the three resets.

The panel header shows a summary, for example *100.0 % · 0.0°*, and the ◐ badge when the image is adjusted. Click the header to collapse or expand the panel. Expanded, it has four groups:

- **Zoom** in percent, 10–800. The − and + buttons change it by 0.1 % (with `Shift` 1 %). The percentage is applied on top of the shared zoom in the toolbar. Clicking *Fit to screen*, *Fit to width*, *Actual size (1:1)* or *Custom size*, or double-clicking the page, sets the zoom back to 100 % on both the left and the right page, even when compare mode is off. Position, rotation and image are kept.
- **Position**: horizontal and vertical offset in pixels. Drag the page, or select the move button (four arrows) and use the arrow keys: 1 px per press, 10 px with `Shift`.
- **Rotation** in degrees. The ↺ and ↻ buttons turn the page 0.1° (with `Shift` 1°); a counter-clockwise turn shows as a negative number. The outer buttons in the rotation group (tooltip *Rotates 90° and keeps the fine tuning*) turn a quarter turn and keep the fine tuning – 4.6° becomes 94.6°.

- **Image**: brightness and contrast 0–200 (100 = unchanged), grayscale 0–100 (0 = in color) and the *Invert* checkbox.

At the bottom there are three resets: **Reset all (layout and image)**, **Reset layout (zoom, position, rotation)** and **Reset image (brightness, contrast, color)**. A button is gray when there is nothing to reset.

In the fields you can type with a decimal comma or a decimal point – 12,5 and 12.5 both work. `Enter` applies the value, `Esc` undoes what you typed.

While a page's panel is expanded, you **drag** the page to move it instead of scrolling, and `Ctrl` + the mouse wheel zooms only that page. Collapse the panel, or switch Fine tuning off, to scroll and zoom as usual again.

In compare mode the toolbar's reset button does the same as *Reset all (layout and image)* for the active page. The toolbar's 90° buttons keep the fine tuning, and the brightness and contrast buttons show the active page's value.

▾ The zoom buttons behind the ring and the toolbar's zoom

In compare mode, each page also has its own zoom buttons, tucked behind the colored ring at the top left. Point at the ring (or tab to it) and they fold out below it: zoom in, the factor (for example ×1.0, always with a decimal point) and zoom out. The factor is the same value as *Zoom* in the Fine-tune panel (×1.1 = 110 %). Each click changes it by 0.1, and any decimals you fine-tuned are kept.

The toolbar's *Fit to screen*, *Fit to width*, *Actual size (1:1)* and *Custom size* set both pages' factor back to ×1.0 but keep position and rotation.

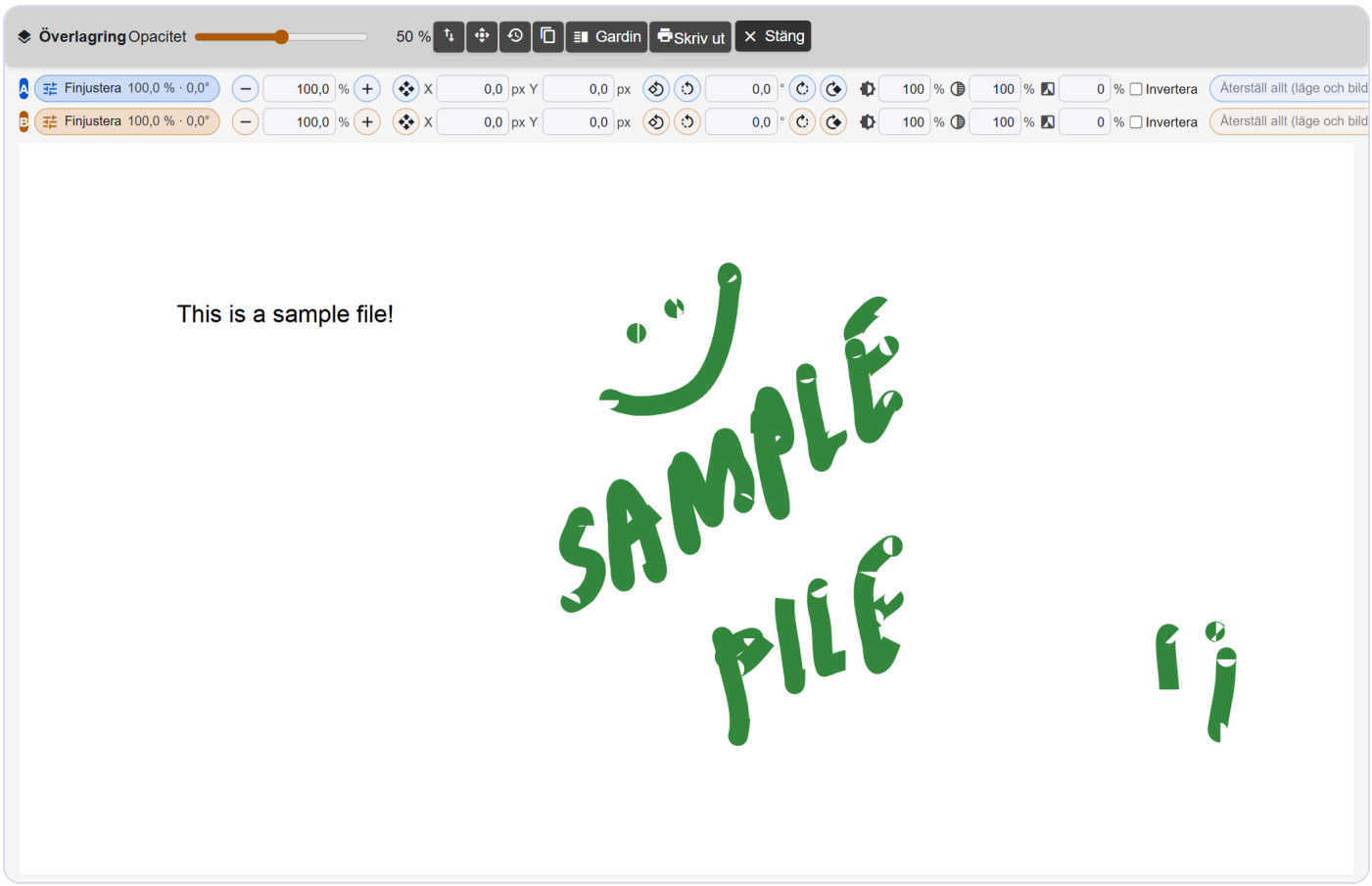


The ring with the zoom buttons folded out. Plus, the factor and minus below the ring.

4. Lay the pages on top of each other (overlay)

Small differences are easiest to see when the pages lie on top of each other. In the overlay view, page A (left, blue) lies underneath and page B (right, orange) on top, and you decide how transparent the top page should be.

1. Click the **overlay button** (stacked layers) next to the compare button – it is only there while two pages are being compared. The view takes over the whole window, with a toolbar of its own.
2. Drag the **Opacity** slider until you can see both pages. The first time, the view opens at 50 %.
3. Move page B until it lies exactly on page A: drag the page, or use the **B** panel above the pages. `Ctrl` + the mouse wheel zooms the top page.
4. Click **Close** (or press `Esc`) when you are done. You are back in the compare view, and the calibration is kept.



The overlay view. The *Opacity* slider controls the top page. The panels *A* and *B* are the same Fine-tune panels as in the compare view.

The buttons in the view's toolbar:

- **Swap which page is on top** (up and down arrows) puts the other page on top. The *Opacity* slider always controls the page on top.
- **Nudge mode** (the button with arrows around a dot): while it is on, the arrow keys move the top page 1 px per press – not while the cursor is in a field.
- **Reset to the alignment from the compare view**: when the view opens, ODV takes a snapshot of both pages' adjustments. The button goes back to it – zoom, position, rotation and image.
- **Copy the calibration as JSON (for support)** puts both pages' values on the clipboard as text, so you can paste them into a support case. *Calibration copied* is shown for a moment.
- **Curtain** opens the curtain view with the same calibration, see Drag a border between the pages. **Print** is described in Print from the comparison.

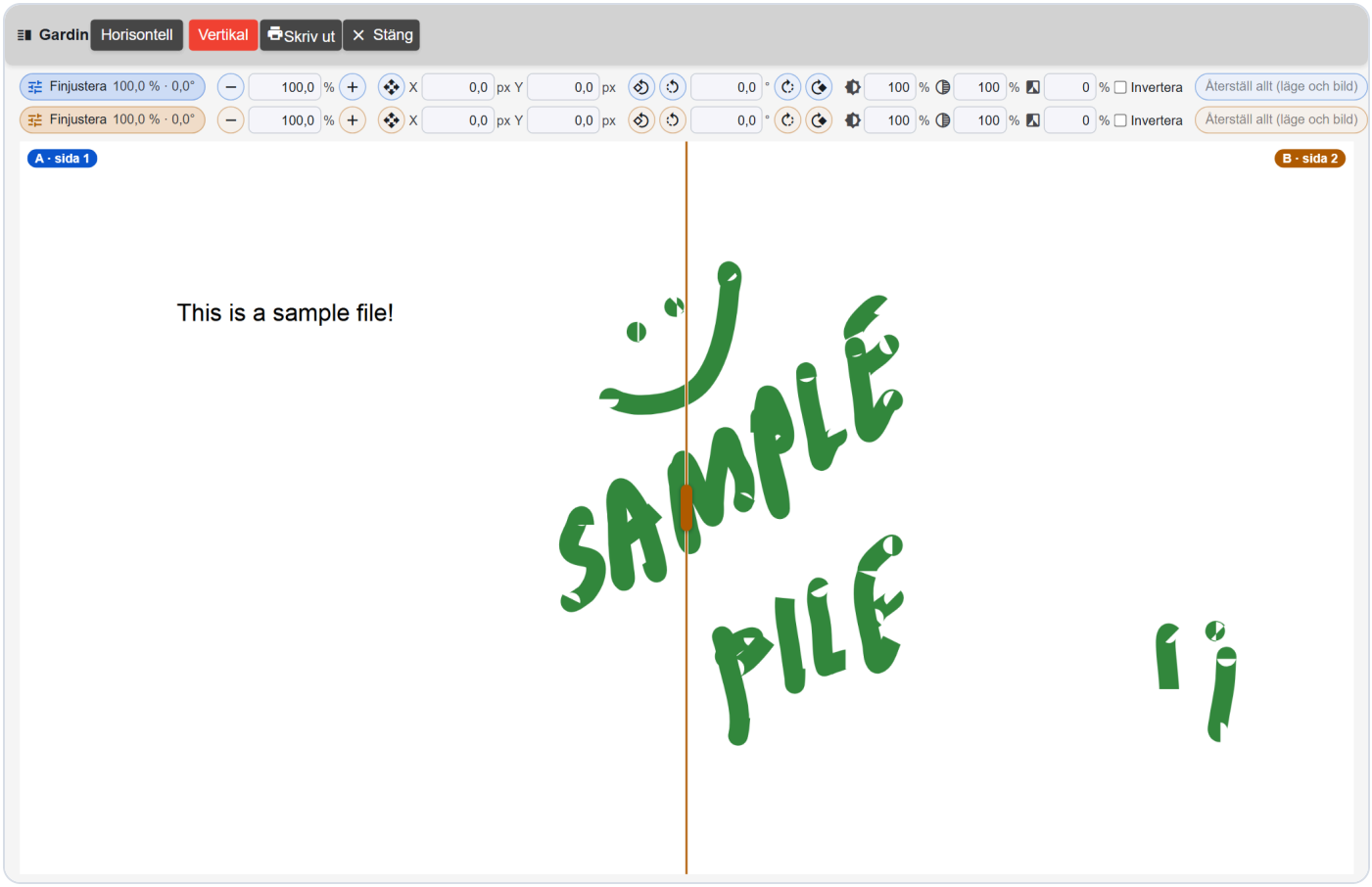
The panels *A* and *B* open expanded here, regardless of the choice in the usual toolbar; click a header to collapse it. The next time you open the overlay view, the opacity and the top page are as you left them.

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5. Drag a border between the pages (curtain)

In the curtain view the two calibrated pages lie in the same place, and a border you drag splits the picture: on one half you see page A, on the other page B. That shows at once whether lines and text continue unbroken across the border.

1. Click **Curtain** in the overlay view's toolbar. You can also click the curtain button next to the overlay button in the usual toolbar – it is gray until you have opened the overlay view once.
2. Drag the grip on the border. The grip has keyboard focus when the view opens, so the arrow keys move it straight away: 1 % per press, 10 % with `Shift`.
3. Choose **Horizontal** if you would rather have a border that runs across the page. The view always opens with **Vertical** and the border at 50 %.
4. Click **Close** (or press `Esc`). You are back where you opened the curtain view from: the overlay view or the compare view.



The curtain view. Page A to the left of the border, page B to the right. The labels in the corners show which page, with its page number, is where.

- **Vertical**: the border is upright, page A shows on the left and page B on the right.
  Horizontal: the border runs across the page, page A above and page B below. Each direction remembers its own position as long as the view is open.
- The labels in the corners show which page is where, for example *A · page 1* and *B · page 2*.
- The panels *A* and *B* are expanded here too and change the same calibration as the other views.
- **Print** is described in Print from the comparison.

If the overlay view is switched off in your installation, the curtain opens straight away, with the compare view's calibration.

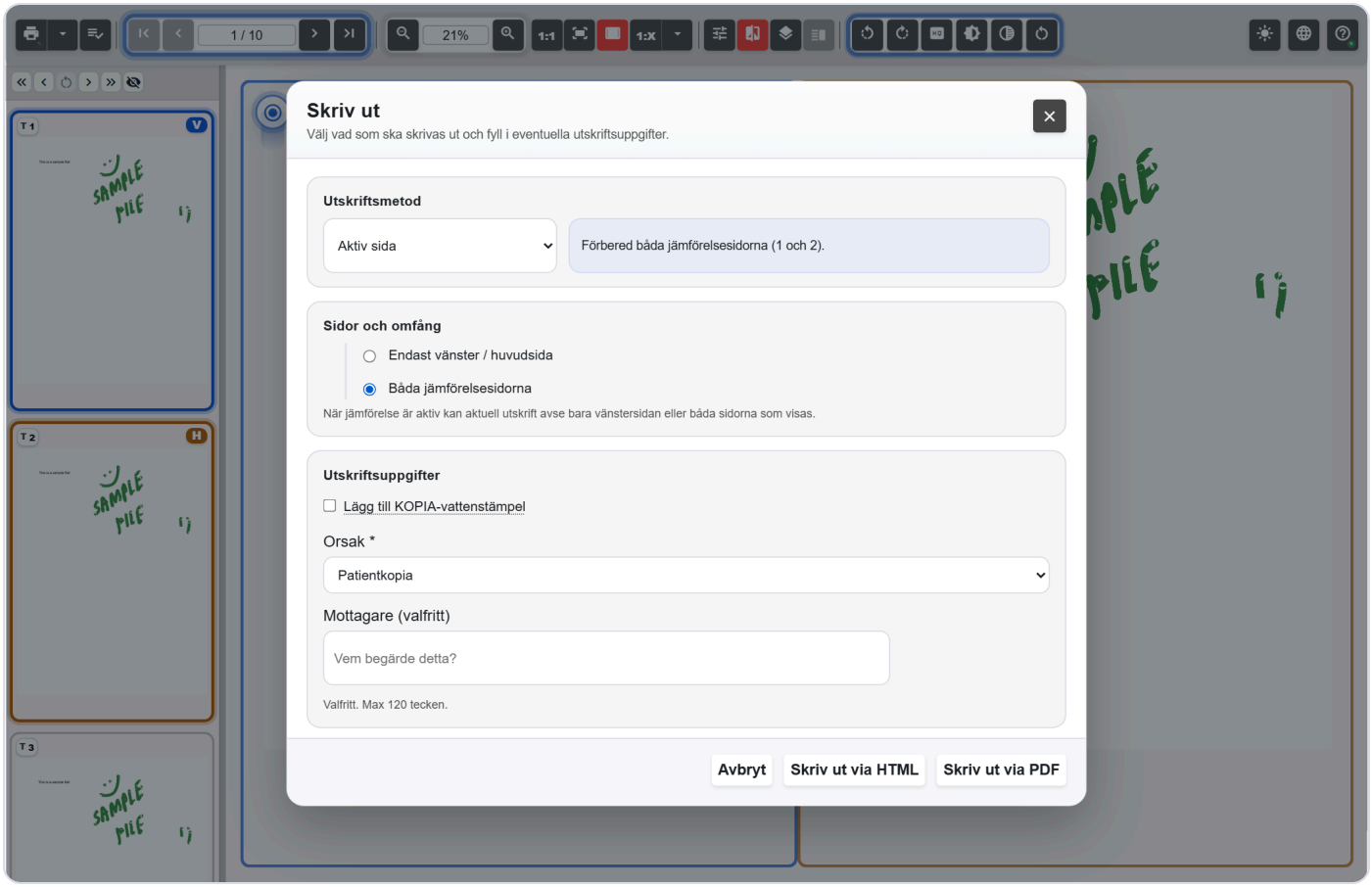
6. Print from the comparison

There are three ways to get the comparison on paper or as a PDF. All of them use ODV's usual print dialog. You fill in reason, recipient and watermark as usual – see the section Print in the Getting started guide. At the bottom you choose **Print via HTML** or **Print via PDF**, depending on which buttons you have. The **Save PDF** button is only there if your organization has enabled it.

Side by side – two pages on the printout:

1. Click the print button in the toolbar.
2. Choose the **Active page** print method.
3. Under *Pages and scope* there are two options: *Left / primary page only* (preselected) and *Both compare pages*. Choose **Both compare pages**.
4. Fill in the details and click **Print via HTML** or **Print via PDF**.

You get two pages, exactly as you see them: zoom, position, rotation and image adjustments are included. If you leave the preselected *Left / primary page only*, only the left page is printed – even when the right page is active. Every other print method prints the pages as they are in the archive.



The Active page print method in compare mode. *Both compare pages* gives two pages on the printout.

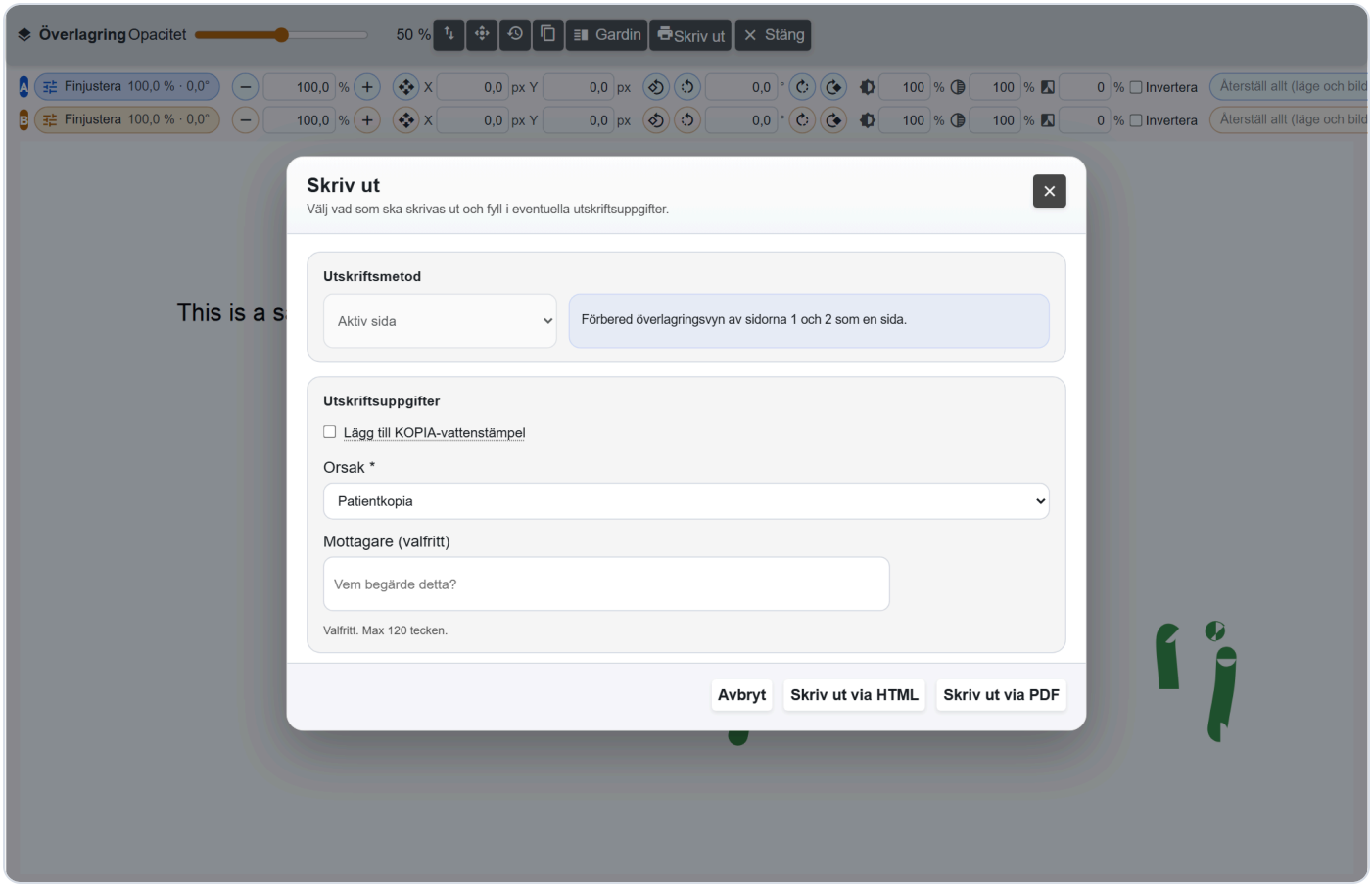
Print the overlay view: click **Print** in the overlay view's toolbar. You get one composed page of the visible area, with the pages laid on top of each other as on screen: the lower page opaque, the top page at the slider's opacity, and both with their calibration.

Print the curtain view: click **Print** in the curtain view's toolbar. You get one composed page of the visible area, with the border's direction and position as at that moment and both pages' calibration.

When you print from one of the two views, the dialog is simpler:

- The print method is locked to *Active page*, and the *Pages and scope* section is not there.
- The summary says, for example, *Prepare the overlay view of pages 1 and 2 as one page*.
- The result is always **one composed page**, with the same header, footer and watermark as other prints. Toolbars, the slider, the grip and the corner labels are not printed.

The **Print** button in a view appears only once all pages have loaded, and it is gray while a PDF is being prepared.



Printing from the overlay view. The same dialog as usual, but the method is locked to *Active page* and the result is one page.

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7. What your organization may have switched off

Everything in this guide is included from the start, but whoever manages the installation can switch parts of it off. If a button described here is missing, that is probably why – ask your local support.

- **Fine tuning, overlay and curtain together.** Then there is no Fine tuning button, no panels, no zoom buttons behind the ring and neither of the two views. Side-by-side comparison and its printing remain.
- **The overlay view or the curtain view separately.** A switched-off view has no button at all, neither in the toolbar nor in the other view. If the overlay is switched off, the curtain opens straight away, and the curtain button is never gray.
- **Printing from a view.** The view remains but has no Print button. The button is also missing while the pages are still loading. Side-by-side printing is not affected.

- **The toolbar's image buttons in compare mode.** Normally brightness and contrast show the active page's values. An installation can hide the 90° buttons, brightness, contrast and reset while a Fine-tune panel is expanded – the panel has the same controls. The *Increase PDF page resolution* button always remains.

<details>
<summary>For whoever manages the installation: the settings behind this section</summary>

The settings live in `odv.site.config.js`. `fineTune.enabled` switches off fine tuning, overlay and curtain together. `compare.overlay.enabled` and `compare.curtain.enabled` control whether each view can be opened. `compare.overlay.print.enabled` and `compare.curtain.print.enabled` control each view's **Print** button. All five default to `true`; only the value `false` switches one off. `compare.adjust.toolbarMode` is `'mirror'` (default: the toolbar shows the page's values) or `'hide'` (the image buttons give way while a panel is expanded).
</details>

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8. The keys in the comparison

Key	Does this
`Arrow Right`	Opens the comparison, or makes the right page active when the comparison is already running.
`Arrow Left`	Makes the left page active. If it is already active, the comparison ends.
`Shift` + button or key	Applies to the page that is not active, one click or key press at a time.
`Shift` + click on a thumbnail	Replaces the page that is not active.
`Ctrl` + `Arrow Left` / `Arrow Right`	Turns the active page 90° and keeps the fine tuning.
`Enter` / `Esc` / `Arrow Up` / `Arrow Down` in a field in the Fine-tune panel	Applies the value / undoes / steps the value (with `Shift` ten steps).
Arrow keys on the move button	Move the page 1 px, with `Shift` 10 px.

Key	Does this
`Ctrl` + mouse wheel over a page with an expanded panel	Zooms only that page, 1 % per notch.
Arrow keys on the Opacity slider	Left/down −1 %, right/up +1 %, with `Shift` 10 %. `Home` 0 %, `End` 100 %.
Arrow keys in nudge mode	Move the top page 1 px, with `Shift` 10 px.
Arrow keys on the curtain's border	Left/up −1 %, right/down +1 %, with `Shift` 10 %.
`Esc`	Closes the overlay view or the curtain view – not while the cursor is in a text field.

While the overlay view or the curtain view is open, the usual keyboard shortcuts are paused. All keyboard shortcuts in ODV are listed in the guide More features.

Short checklist for comparison

- ✓ Blue frame = left page (A), orange frame = right page (B). The filled ring shows which page is active.
- ✓ *Fine tuning* in the toolbar shows the Fine-tune panels. The adjustments are kept when you hide them.
- ✓ Open the overlay view once – then the curtain can be opened.
- ✓ Printing from the overlay view or the curtain view always gives one page. The *Active page* print method with *Both compare pages* gives two.
- ✓ Nothing is saved in the archive. Everything you have set disappears when you load new documents.

Back to Getting started with OpenDocViewer. This guide covers OpenDocViewer 2.11.
Updated 2026-10-25.